Chapter 6 · Story

Two invitations. Different reasons to care.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invitation · c06s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

A potential volunteer worries about the time commitment. What information would help most?

A A second celebrity endorsement.

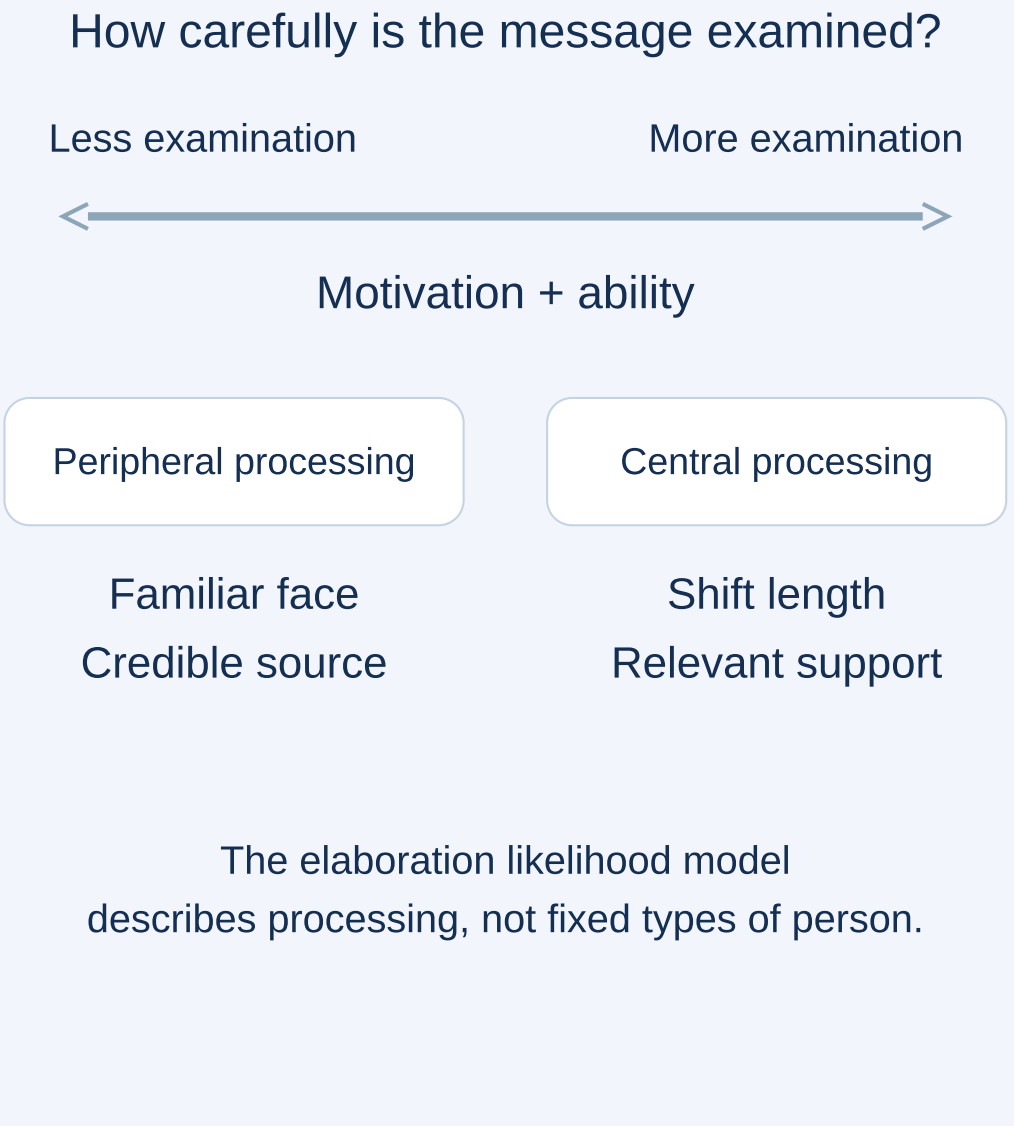
B Shift length, support, and an optional trial.

C A stronger claim that this is unmissable.

Suggested answer: B. Shift length, support, and an optional trial give the volunteer relevant information about the commitment.

Attention and evaluation are different jobs.

- **Attitude**: an evaluation of something.
- **Elaboration likelihood model**: motivation and ability shape careful thinking.
- **Central processing**: examine relevant arguments.
- **Peripheral processing**: give more weight to cues such as familiarity.



The same person can process different messages more or less carefully.

A norm must be true to be useful.

- **Descriptive norm**: what people do.
- **Injunctive norm**: what people approve.
- A clear request needs an easy next step.

What happens and what is approved

Descriptive norm



“Many residents volunteer.”
A claim about what people do.

Injunctive norm



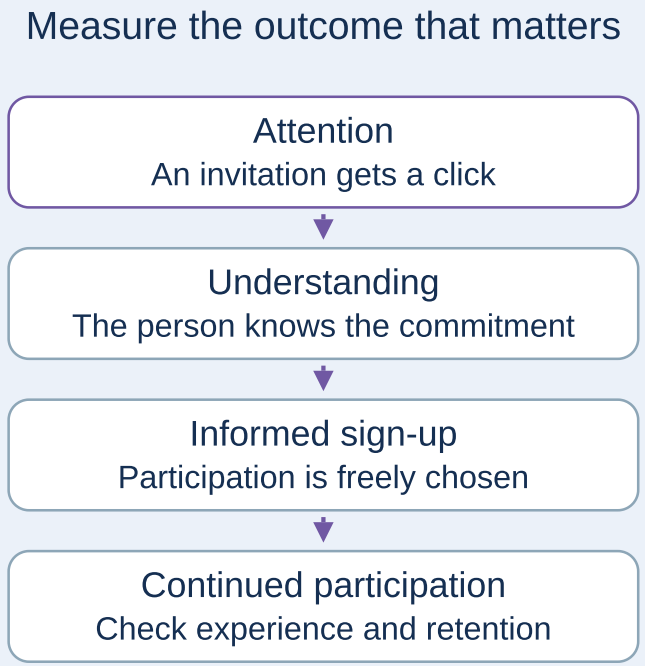
“Our community values volunteering.”
A claim about what people approve.

These are example claims; check their truth.
Highlighting low participation can normalize it.

Behavior and approval are different claims; both need evidence.

What can we really conclude?

Persuasion depends on the audience, topic, source, and outcome being measured. A changed survey answer is not the same outcome as sustained behavior change. Treat a revised invitation as a hypothesis to test. An increase in clicks does not establish that people understood the commitment or will continue volunteering. Compare comprehension, informed sign-ups, and retention. Ask whether people understood the effort involved and felt able to decline. Those measures are closer to the decision the café needs to support.



A click alone does not establish these later outcomes.

Measure later outcomes rather than assuming them from clicks.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Few residents currently volunteer. Which invitation is defensible?

A “Everyone here already volunteers.”

B “Hardly anyone helps—don’t be like them.”

C “Try a supported two-hour shift; here is what it involves.”

Suggested answer: C. A supported two-hour trial is a concrete, checkable request. Its effect on informed participation still needs evaluation.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> What makes central processing more likely?

> Distinguish descriptive and injunctive norms.

1. Central processing is more likely when someone is motivated and has the ability, attention, and information to examine the arguments.

2. Descriptive norms concern what people do. Injunctive norms concern approval.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Rewrite a low-stakes invitation. State the decision, relevant reason, effort required, and next step. Remove social-proof claims you cannot substantiate.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.